

Departments of France

In the administrative divisions of France, the **department** (French: *département*, pronounced [depaʁtɑ̃mɑ̃] ⓘ) is one of the three levels of government under the national level ("territorial collectivities"), between the administrative regions and the communes. There are a total of 101 departments, consisting of ninety-six departments in metropolitan France, and five overseas departments (which are also classified as overseas regions). Departments are further subdivided into 333 arrondissements and 2,054 cantons (as of 2023).^[1] These last two levels of government have no political autonomy, instead serving as the administrative basis for the local organisation of police, fire departments, and, in certain cases, elections.

Each department is administered by an elected body called a departmental council (sing. *conseil départemental*, pl. *conseils départementaux*). From 1800 to April 2015, these were called general councils (sing. *conseil général*, pl. *conseils généraux*).^[2] Each council has a president. Their main areas of responsibility include the management of a number of social and welfare allowances, of junior high school (*collège*) buildings and technical staff, and local roads and school and rural buses, and a contribution to municipal infrastructures.^[3] Local services of the state administration are traditionally organised at departmental level, where the prefect represents the government; however, regions have gained importance since the 2000s, with some department-level services merged into region-level services.

The departments were created in 1790 as a rational replacement of Ancien Régime provinces with a view to strengthen national unity;^[4] the title "department" is used to mean a part of a larger whole.^[5] Almost all of them were named after physical geographical features (rivers, mountains, or coasts), rather than after historical or cultural territories, which could have their own loyalties, or after their own administrative seats. The division of France into departments was a project particularly identified with the French revolutionary leader the Abbé Sieyès,^{[6][7]} although it had already been frequently discussed and written about by many politicians and thinkers. The earliest known suggestion of it is from 1665 in the writings of d'Argenson.^[8] They have inspired similar divisions in many countries, some of them former French colonies. The 1822 territorial division of Spain (reverted due to the 1823 French

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Départements de France (French)

Location	France
Found in	Regions
Number	101 (not including the Metropolis of Lyon) (as of January 2021)
Possible types	Metropolitan departments Overseas departments
Populations	Largest: Nord, Hauts-de-France—2,613,000 (2022 census) Smallest: Lozère, Occitanie—83,000 (2022 census)
Areas	Largest: French Guiana—83,533.9 km ² (32,252.6 sq mi) Smallest: Paris, Île-de-France—105.4 km ² (40.7 sq mi)
Densities	Largest: Paris, Île-de-France—20,755/km ² (53,760/sq mi) Smallest: French Guiana—3.5/km ² (9.1/sq mi)
Government	Departmental council
Subdivisions	Arrondissements Cantons Communes

intervention ending the trienio liberal) and the 1833 territorial division of Spain, which forms the basis of the present day provinces of Spain with minor modifications, are also based on the French model of departments of roughly equal size.^[9]

Most French departments are assigned a two-digit number, the Official Geographical Code, allocated by the *Institut national de la statistique et des études économiques (Insee)*.^[10] Overseas departments have a three-digit number. The number is used, for example, in the postal code and was, until the introduction of the SIV scheme in 2009, part of the vehicle registration plate number. Residents commonly use the numbers to refer to their own department or a neighbouring one, for example inhabitants of Loiret may refer to their department as "the 45". More distant departments are generally referred to by their names, as few people know the numbers of all the departments.

In 2014, President François Hollande proposed abolishing departmental councils by 2020, which would have maintained the departments as administrative divisions, and transferring their powers to other levels of governance.^[11] This reform project has since been scrapped.

History

The first French territorial departments were proposed in 1665 by Marc-René d'Argenson to serve as administrative areas purely for the Ponts et Chaussées (Bridges and Highways) infrastructure administration.^[12]

Before the French Revolution, France gained territory gradually through the annexation of a mosaic of independent entities. By the end of the Ancien Régime it was organised into provinces. During the Revolution they were dissolved, partly in order to weaken old loyalties. The National Constituent Assembly decided to create a more uniform division into departments (*département*) and districts in late 1789.^[13] The process began on 4 August 1789 with the elimination of provincial privileges, and a 22 December 1789 decree (with letters patent in January 1790) provided for the termination of the provincial governments.^[13]

The modern department system, as all-purpose units of the government, was decreed on 26 February 1790 (with letters patent on 4 March 1790) by the National Constituent Assembly.^[13] Their boundaries served two purposes:

- Boundaries were chosen to break up France's historical regions in an attempt to erase cultural differences and build a more homogeneous nation.
- Boundaries were set so that every settlement in the country was within a day's ride of the capital of a department. This was a security measure, intended to keep the entire national territory under close control.

The old nomenclature was carefully avoided in naming the new departments. Most were named after an area's principal river or other physical features. Even Paris was in the department of Seine. Savoy, during its temporary occupation, became the department of Mont-Blanc.^[14] The provinces continued to exist administratively until 21 September 1791.^[13]



Geometrical proposition rejected



French provinces before 1790 (color) and today's departments (black borders)

The number of departments, initially 83, had been increased to 130 by 1809 with the territorial gains of the Republic and of the First French Empire.^[15] Following the defeats of Napoleon in 1814–1815 the Congress of Vienna returned France to its pre-war size and the number of departments was reduced to 86 (three of the original departments having been split). In 1860 France acquired the County of Nice and Savoy, which led to the creation of three new departments.^[16] Two were added from the new Savoyard territory, while the department of Alpes-Maritimes was created from Nice and a portion of the Var department.^[16] The 89 departments were given numbers based on the alphabetical order of their names.^[17]



Departments at the maximum extent of the First French Empire (1812)

The department of Bas-Rhin and parts of Meurthe, Moselle, Vosges and Haut-Rhin were ceded to the German Empire in 1871 following France's defeat in the Franco-Prussian War. A small part of Haut-Rhin, however, remained French and became known as the Territoire de Belfort; the remaining parts of Meurthe and Moselle were merged into a new Meurthe-et-Moselle department. When France regained the ceded departments after World War I, the Territoire de Belfort was not reintegrated into Haut-Rhin. In 1922 it became France's 90th department. Likewise the Lorraine departments were not changed back to their original boundaries, and a new Moselle department was created in the regained territory, with slightly different boundaries from the pre-war department of the same name.

The reorganisation of Île-de-France in 1968 and the division of Corsica in 1975 added six more departments, raising the total in Metropolitan France to 96. By 2011, when the overseas collectivity of Mayotte became a department, joining the earlier overseas departments of the Republic (all created in 1946) – French Guiana, Guadeloupe, Martinique and Réunion – the total number of departments in the French Republic had become 101. In 2015 the Urban Community of Lyon was split from Rhône to form the Métropole de Lyon, a *sui generis* entity, with the powers of both an intercommunality and those of a department on its territory, formally classified as a "territorial collectivity with particular status" (French: *collectivité territoriale à statut particulier*) and as such not belonging to any department. As of 2019 Corse-du-Sud and Haute-Corse are still administrative departments, although they no longer have the status of departmental "territorial collectivities": region and department functions have been managed by a "single territorial collectivity" since 2018.

Despite the intention to avoid the old nomenclature, often the names of pre-1790 provinces remained in use. For example, the name of Berry, though no longer having an official status, remains in widespread use in daily life.

General characteristics

Government and administration

The departmental seat of government is known as the prefecture (*préfecture*) or *chef-lieu de département* and is generally a town of some importance roughly at the geographical centre of the department. This was determined according to the time taken to travel on horseback from the periphery of the department. The goal was for the prefecture to be accessible on horseback from any town in the department within 24 hours. The prefecture is not necessarily the largest city in the department: for instance, in Saône-et-Loire department the capital is Mâcon, but the largest city is Chalon-sur-Saône. Departments may be divided into arrondissements. The capital of an arrondissement is called a subprefecture (*sous-préfecture*) or *chef-lieu d'arrondissement*.

Each department is administered by a departmental council (*conseil départemental*), an assembly elected for six years by universal suffrage, with the President of the Departmental Council as executive of the department. Before 1982, the chief executive of the department was the prefect (*préfet*), who represents the Government of France in



each department and is appointed by the President of the French Republic. The prefect is assisted by one or more sub-prefects (*sous-préfet*) based in the subprefectures of the department. Since 1982, the prefect retains only the powers that are not delegated to the department councils. In practice, their role has been largely limited to preventing local policy from conflicting with national policy.

The departments are further divided into communes, governed by municipal councils. As of 2025, there were 34,746 communes in France. In the overseas territories, some communes play a role at departmental level. Paris, the country's capital city, is a commune as well as a

department.

In mainland France (metropolitan France, excluding Corsica), the median land area of a department is 5,965 km² (2,303 sq mi), which is two-and-a-half times the median land area of the ceremonial counties of England and the preserved counties of Wales and slightly more than three-and-half times the median land area of a county of the United States. At the 2001 census, the median population of a department in continental France was 511,000 inhabitants, which is 21 times the median population of a United States county, but less than two-thirds of the median population of a ceremonial county of England and Wales. Most of the departments have an area of between 4,000 and 8,000 km² (1500 to 3000 sq. mi), and a population between 320,000 and 1 million. The largest in area is Gironde (10,000 km² (3,900 sq mi)), while the smallest is the city of Paris (105 km² (41 sq mi)). The most populous is Nord (2,550,000) and the least populous is Lozère (74,000).

Numbering

The departments are numbered: their two-digit numbers appear in postal codes, in INSEE codes (including "social security numbers") and on vehicle registration plates. Initially the numbers corresponded to the alphabetical order of the names of the departments, but several changed their names and some have been divided, so the correspondence became less exact. Alphanumeric codes 2A and 2B were used for Corsica while it was split but it has since reverted to 20. The two-digit code "98" is used by Monaco. Together with the ISO 3166-1 alpha-2 country code FR, the numbers form the ISO 3166-2 country subdivision codes for the metropolitan departments. The overseas departments have three digits.

Relation to national government

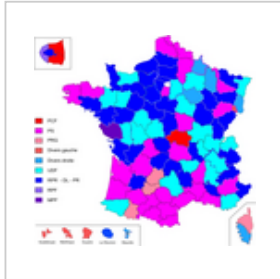
Originally, the relationship between the departments and the central government was left somewhat ambiguous. While citizens in each department elected their own officials, the local governments were subordinated to the central government, becoming instruments of national integration. By 1793, however, the revolutionary government had turned the departments into transmission belts for policies enacted in Paris. With few exceptions, the departments had this role until the early 1960s.



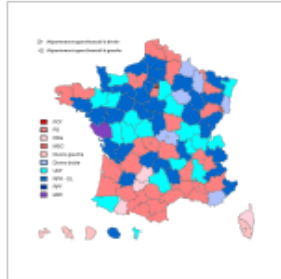
Population density in the departments (2007). The broken lines mark the approximate boundaries of the empty diagonal. The solid line is the Le Havre-Marseille line, to the east of which lives 60% of the French population.

Political party preferences

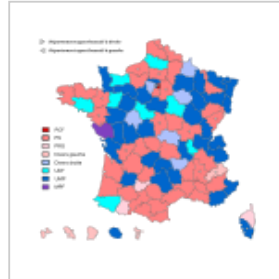
These maps cannot be used as a useful resource of voter preferences, because Departmental Councils are elected on a two-round system, which drastically limits the chances of fringe parties, if they are not supported on one of the two rounds by a moderate party. After the 1992 election, the left had a majority in only 21 of the 100 departments; after the 2011 election, the left dominated 61 of the 100 departments. (Mayotte only became a department after the election.)



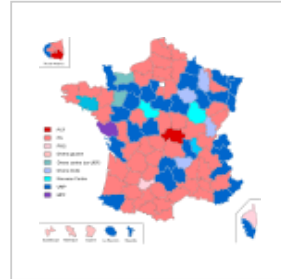
Party affiliation of the
General Council
Presidents of the
various departments in
the cantonal elections
of 1998



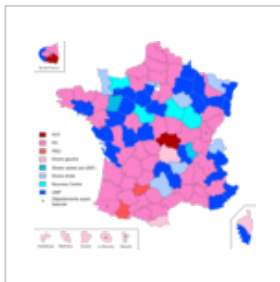
Party affiliation of the
General Council
Presidents of the
various departments in
the elections of 2001



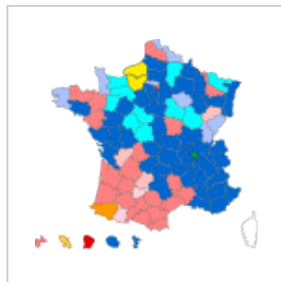
Party affiliation of the
General Council
Presidents of the
various departments in
the elections of 2004



Party affiliation of the
General Council
Presidents of the
various departments in
the elections of 2008



Party affiliation of the
General Council
Presidents of the
various departments in
the elections of 2011



Party affiliation of the
General Council
Presidents of the
various departments in
the elections of 2015

Key to the parties:

- Divers Centre = Independents of the centre or Democratic Movement (Mouvement démocrate)
- Divers Droite (DVD) = Independent conservatives
- Divers Gauche (DVG) = Independent left-wing politicians
- MPF = Movement for France (Mouvement pour la France) (right)
- Nouveau Centre = New Centre (centre or centre-right)
- PCF = French Communist Party (Parti communiste français)
- PRG = Radical Party of the Left (Parti radical de gauche)
- PS = Socialist Party (Parti socialiste)
- UDF = Union for French Democracy (Union pour la démocratie française) succeeded by Democratic Movement
- UMP = Union for a Popular Movement (Union pour un mouvement populaire)

Future

The removal of one or more levels of local government has been discussed for some years; in particular, the option of removing the departmental level. Frédéric Lefebvre, spokesman for the UMP, said in December 2008 that the fusion of the departments with the regions was a matter to be dealt with soon. This was soon refuted by Édouard Balladur and Gérard Longuet, members of the committee for the reform of local authorities, known as the Balladur Committee.^[18]

In January 2008, the Attali Commission recommended that the departmental level of government should be eliminated within ten years.^[19]

Nevertheless, the Balladur Committee has not retained this proposition and does not advocate the disappearance of the departments, but simply "favors the voluntary grouping of departments", which it suggests also for the regions, with the aim of reducing the number of regions to 15.^[20] This committee advocates, on the contrary, the suppression of the cantons.^[20]

Maps and tables

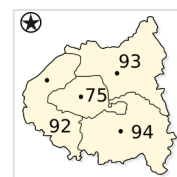
Current departments

Each department has a coat of arms and a flag with which it is commonly associated, though not all are officially recognised or used.

INSEE code	Arms ¹	Date of establishment	Department	Capital	Region	Named after
01		26 February 1790	<u>Ain</u>	<u>Bourg-en-Bresse</u>	 <u>Auvergne-Rhône-Alpes</u>	<u>Ain (river)</u>
02			<u>Aisne</u>	<u>Laon</u>	 <u>Hauts-de-France</u>	<u>Aisne (river)</u>
03			<u>Allier</u>	<u>Moulins</u>	 <u>Auvergne-Rhône-Alpes</u>	<u>Allier (river)</u>
04			<u>Alpes-de-Haute-Provence</u> ²	<u>Digne-les-Bains</u>	 <u>Provence-Alpes-Côte d'Azur</u>	<u>Alps mountains and Provence region</u>
05			<u>Hautes-Alpes</u>	<u>Gap</u>		<u>Alps mountains</u>
06			<u>Alpes-Maritimes</u>	<u>Nice</u>		
07			<u>Ardèche</u>	<u>Privas</u>	 <u>Auvergne-Rhône-Alpes</u>	<u>Ardèche (river)</u>
08			<u>Ardennes</u>	<u>Charleville-Mézières</u>	 <u>Grand Est</u>	<u>Ardennes Forest</u>
09			<u>Ariège</u>	<u>Foix</u>	 <u>Occitanie</u>	<u>Ariège (river)</u>
10			<u>Aube</u>	<u>Troyes</u>	 <u>Grand Est</u>	<u>Aube (river)</u>
11			<u>Aude</u>	<u>Carcassonne</u>	 <u>Occitanie</u>	<u>Aude (river)</u>
12			<u>Aveyron</u>	<u>Rodez</u>		<u>Aveyron (river)</u>
13			<u>Bouches-du-Rhône</u>	<u>Marseille</u>	 <u>Provence-Alpes-Côte d'Azur</u>	<u>Rhône (river)</u>
14			<u>Calvados</u>	<u>Caen</u>	 <u>Normandy</u>	Latin <i>calva dorsa</i> ("bare backs"), referring to two offshore rocks
15			<u>Cantal</u>	<u>Aurillac</u>	 <u>Auvergne-Rhône-Alpes</u>	<u>Mounts of Cantal</u>
16			<u>Charente</u>	<u>Angoulême</u>	 <u>Nouvelle-Aquitaine</u>	<u>Charente (river)</u>
17			<u>Charente-Maritime</u> ³	<u>La Rochelle</u>		
18			<u>Cher</u>	<u>Bourges</u>	 <u>Centre-Val de Loire</u>	<u>Cher (river)</u>
19			<u>Corrèze</u>	<u>Tulle</u>	 <u>Nouvelle-Aquitaine</u>	<u>Corrèze (river)</u>
2A		1 January 1979	<u>Corse-du-Sud</u> ¹⁹	<u>Ajaccio</u>	 <u>Corsica</u>	<u>Island of Corsica and South cardinal direction</u>
2B			<u>Haute-Corse</u> ¹⁹	<u>Bastia</u>		<u>Island of Corsica</u>



Regions and departments of metropolitan France; the numbers are those of the first column (except for Corsica, which shows the division of the island until 2018, and the division of the Metropolis of Lyon from Rhône is not shown).



The departments in the immediate vicinity of Paris; the numbers are those of the first column.

21		26 February 1790	<u>Côte-d'Or</u>	<u>Dijon</u>	 Bourgogne-Franche-Comté	<u>Côte d'Or (escarpment)</u>
22			<u>Côtes-d'Armor</u> ⁴	<u>Saint-Brieuc</u>	 Brittany	<u>coasts of Armorica</u>
23			<u>Creuse</u>	<u>Guéret</u>	 Nouvelle-Aquitaine	<u>Creuse (river)</u>
24			<u>Dordogne</u>	<u>Périgueux</u>		<u>Dordogne (river)</u>
25			<u>Doubs</u>	<u>Besançon</u>	 Bourgogne-Franche-Comté	<u>Doubs (river)</u>
26			<u>Drôme</u>	<u>Valence</u>	 Auvergne-Rhône-Alpes	<u>Drôme (river)</u>
27			<u>Eure</u>	<u>Évreux</u>	 Normandy	<u>Eure (river)</u>
28			<u>Eure-et-Loir</u>	<u>Chartres</u>	 Centre-Val de Loire	<u>Eure and Loir rivers</u>
29			<u>Finistère</u>	<u>Quimper</u>	 Brittany	Latin <i>Finis Terrae</i> (the end of the earth, land's end)
30			<u>Gard</u>	<u>Nîmes</u>	 Occitanie	<u>Occitan name for Gardon river</u>
31			<u>Haute-Garonne</u>	<u>Toulouse</u>		<u>Garonne (river)</u>
32			<u>Gers</u>	<u>Auch</u>		<u>Gers (river)</u>
33			<u>Gironde</u> ⁵	<u>Bordeaux</u>	 Nouvelle-Aquitaine	<u>Gironde estuary</u>
34			<u>Hérault</u>	<u>Montpellier</u>	 Occitanie	<u>Hérault (river)</u>
35			<u>Ille-et-Vilaine</u>	<u>Rennes</u>	 Brittany	<u>Ille and Vilaine rivers</u>
36			<u>Indre</u>	<u>Châteauroux</u>	 Centre-Val de Loire	<u>Indre (river)</u>
37			<u>Indre-et-Loire</u>	<u>Tours</u>		<u>Indre and Loire rivers</u>
38			<u>Isère</u>	<u>Grenoble</u>	 Auvergne-Rhône-Alpes	<u>Isère (river)</u>
39			<u>Jura</u>	<u>Lons-le-Saunier</u>	 Bourgogne-Franche-Comté	<u>Jura Mountains</u>
40			<u>Landes</u>	<u>Mont-de-Marsan</u>	 Nouvelle-Aquitaine	<u>Heathlands (<i>lande</i>) that dominated the region at the time</u>
41			<u>Loir-et-Cher</u>	<u>Blois</u>	 Centre-Val de Loire	<u>Loir and Cher rivers</u>
42		12 August 1793	<u>Loire</u>	<u>Saint-Étienne</u>	 Auvergne-Rhône-Alpes	<u>Loire (river)</u>
43		26 February 1790	<u>Haute-Loire</u>	<u>Le Puy-en-Velay</u>		
44			<u>Loire-Atlantique</u> ⁶	<u>Nantes</u>	 Pays de la Loire	<u>Loire (river) and Atlantic</u>

						Ocean
45			<u>Loiret</u>	<u>Orléans</u>	 <u>Centre-Val de Loire</u>	<u>Loiret (river)</u>
46			<u>Lot</u>	<u>Cahors</u>	 <u>Occitanie</u>	<u>Lot (river)</u>
47			<u>Lot-et-Garonne</u>	<u>Agen</u>	 <u>Nouvelle-Aquitaine</u>	<u>Lot and Garonne rivers</u>
48			<u>Lozère</u>	<u>Mende</u>	 <u>Occitanie</u>	<u>Mont Lozère</u>
49			<u>Maine-et-Loire</u> ⁷	<u>Angers</u>	 <u>Pays de la Loire</u>	<u>Maine and Loire rivers</u>
50			<u>Manche</u>	<u>Saint-Lô</u>	 <u>Normandy</u>	<u>English Channel</u>
51			<u>Marne</u>	<u>Châlons-en-Champagne</u>	 <u>Grand Est</u>	<u>Marne (river)</u>
52			<u>Haute-Marne</u>	<u>Chaumont</u>		
53			<u>Mayenne</u>	<u>Laval</u>	 <u>Pays de la Loire</u>	<u>Mayenne (river)</u>
54		7 September 1871	<u>Meurthe-et-Moselle</u>	<u>Nancy</u>	 <u>Grand Est</u>	<u>Meurthe and Moselle rivers</u>
55		26 February 1790	<u>Meuse</u>	<u>Bar-le-Duc</u>		<u>Meuse (river)</u>
56			<u>Morbihan</u>	<u>Vannes</u>	 <u>Brittany</u>	<u>Gulf of Morbihan</u>
57			<u>Moselle</u>	<u>Metz</u>	 <u>Grand Est</u>	<u>Moselle (river)</u>
58			<u>Nièvre</u>	<u>Nevers</u>	 <u>Bourgogne-Franche-Comté</u>	<u>Nièvre (river)</u>
59			<u>Nord</u>	<u>Lille</u>	 <u>Hauts-de-France</u>	<u>North cardinal direction</u>
60			<u>Oise</u>	<u>Beauvais</u>		<u>Oise (river)</u>
61			<u>Orne</u>	<u>Alençon</u>	 <u>Normandy</u>	<u>Orne (river)</u>
62			<u>Pas-de-Calais</u>	<u>Arras</u>	 <u>Hauts-de-France</u>	<u>Strait of Dover</u>
63			<u>Puy-de-Dôme</u>	<u>Clermont-Ferrand</u>	 <u>Auvergne-Rhône-Alpes</u>	<u>Puy de Dôme volcano</u>
64			<u>Pyrénées-Atlantiques</u> ⁸	<u>Pau</u>	 <u>Nouvelle-Aquitaine</u>	<u>Pyrenees mountains and Atlantic Ocean</u>
65			<u>Hautes-Pyrénées</u>	<u>Tarbes</u>	 <u>Occitanie</u>	<u>Pyrenees mountains</u>
66			<u>Pyrénées-Orientales</u>	<u>Perpignan</u>		<u>Pyrenees mountains and East cardinal direction</u>
67			<u>Bas-Rhin</u>	<u>Strasbourg</u>	 <u>Grand Est</u>	<u>Rhine (river)</u>

68			<u>Haut-Rhin</u>	<u>Colmar</u>		
69D		12 August 1793	<u>Rhône</u>	<u>Lyon</u> (provisional)	 <u>Auvergne-Rhône-Alpes</u>	<u>Rhône (river)</u>
69M		1 January 2015	<u>Lyon Metropolis</u> ¹⁸	<u>Lyon</u>		commune of <u>Lyon</u>
70		26 February 1790	<u>Haute-Saône</u>	<u>Vesoul</u>	 <u>Bourgogne-Franche-Comté</u>	<u>Saône (river)</u>
71			<u>Saône-et-Loire</u>	<u>Mâcon</u>		<u>Saône and Loire rivers</u>
72			<u>Sarthe</u>	<u>Le Mans</u>	 <u>Pays de la Loire</u>	<u>Sarthe (river)</u>
73		15 June 1860	<u>Savoie</u>	<u>Chambéry</u>	 <u>Auvergne-Rhône-Alpes</u>	region of <u>Savoy</u>
74			<u>Haute-Savoie</u>	<u>Annecy</u>		
75		1 January 1968	<u>Paris</u> ⁹	<u>Paris</u>	 <u>Île-de-France</u>	commune of <u>Paris</u>
76		26 February 1790	<u>Seine-Maritime</u> ¹⁰	<u>Rouen</u>	 <u>Normandy</u>	<u>Seine (river)</u>
77			<u>Seine-et-Marne</u>	<u>Melun</u>	 <u>Île-de-France</u>	<u>Seine and Marne rivers</u>
78		1 January 1968	<u>Yvelines</u> ¹¹	<u>Versailles</u>		<u>Forest of Yvelines</u>
79		26 February 1790	<u>Deux-Sèvres</u>	<u>Niort</u>	 <u>Nouvelle-Aquitaine</u>	<u>Sèvre Nantaise and Sèvre Niortaise rivers</u>
80			<u>Somme</u>	<u>Amiens</u>	 <u>Hauts-de-France</u>	<u>Somme (river)</u>
81			<u>Tarn</u>	<u>Albi</u>		<u>Tarn (river)</u>
82		4 November 1808	<u>Tarn-et-Garonne</u>	<u>Montauban</u>	 <u>Occitanie</u>	<u>Tarn and Garonne rivers</u>
83		26 February 1790	<u>Var</u>	<u>Toulon</u>	 <u>Provence-Alpes-Côte d'Azur</u>	<u>Var (river)</u>
84		25 June 1793	<u>Vaucluse</u>	<u>Avignon</u>		<u>Fontaine de Vaucluse spring</u>
85		26 February 1790	<u>Vendée</u>	<u>La Roche-sur-Yon</u>	 <u>Pays de la Loire</u>	<u>Vendée (river)</u>
86			<u>Vienne</u>	<u>Poitiers</u>	 <u>Nouvelle-Aquitaine</u>	<u>Vienne (river)</u>
87			<u>Haute-Vienne</u>	<u>Limoges</u>		
88			<u>Vosges</u>	<u>Épinal</u>	 <u>Grand Est</u>	<u>Vosges Mountains</u>
89			<u>Yonne</u>	<u>Auxerre</u>	 <u>Bourgogne-Franche-Comté</u>	<u>Yonne (river)</u>
90		11 March 1922	<u>Territoire de Belfort</u>	<u>Belfort</u>		commune of <u>Belfort</u>

91		1 January 1968	Essonne ¹²	Évry-Courcouronnes	 Île-de-France	Essonne (river)
92			Hauts-de-Seine ¹³	Nanterre		Seine (river)
93			Seine-Saint-Denis ¹⁴	Bobigny		Seine (river) and commune of Saint-Denis
94			Val-de-Marne	Créteil		Marne (river)
95			Val-d'Oise	Pontoise ¹⁵		Oise (river)
971		19 March 1946	Guadeloupe ¹⁶	Basse-Terre	 Guadeloupe	Island of Guadeloupe
972			Martinique ¹⁶	Fort-de-France	 Martinique	Island of Martinique
973			Guyane ¹⁶	Cayenne	 French Guiana	The Guianas
974			La Réunion ¹⁶	Saint-Denis	 Réunion	Island of Réunion
976		9 August 2009 31 March 2011 ^[21]	Mayotte ¹⁷	Mamoudzou	 Mayotte	Island of Mayotte

Notes:

- ^{^1} Most of the coats of arms are unofficial
- ^{^2} Alpes-de-Haute-Provence was known as *Basses-Alpes* ('Lower Alps') until 1970
- ^{^3} Charente-Maritime was known as *Charente-Inférieure* ('Lower Charente') until 1941
- ^{^4} Côtes-d'Armor was known as *Côtes-du-Nord* ('Coasts of the North') until 1990
- ^{^5} Gironde was known as *Bec-d'Ambès* ('Beak of Ambès') from 1793 until 1795. The Convention eliminated the name to avoid recalling the outlawed Girondin political faction.
- ^{^6} Loire-Atlantique was known as *Loire-Inférieure* ('Lower Loire') until 1957
- ^{^7} Maine-et-Loire was known as *Mayenne-et-Loire* (*Mayenne* and Loire rivers) until 1791
- ^{^8} Pyrénées-Atlantiques was known as *Basses-Pyrénées* ('Lower Pyrenees') until 1969
- ^{^9} Number 75 was formerly assigned to Seine
- ^{^10} Seine-Maritime was known as *Seine-Inférieure* ('Lower Seine') until 1955
- ^{^11} Number 78 was formerly assigned to *Seine-et-Oise*
- ^{^12} Number 91 was formerly assigned to *Alger*, in French Algeria
- ^{^13} Number 92 was formerly assigned to *Oran*, in French Algeria
- ^{^14} Number 93 was formerly assigned to *Constantine*, in French Algeria
- ^{^15} The prefecture of Val-d'Oise was established in Pontoise when the department was created, but moved *de facto* to the neighbouring commune of *Cergy*; currently, both part of the *ville nouvelle* of *Cergy-Pontoise*
- ^{^16} The overseas departments each constitute a *region* and enjoy a status identical to *metropolitan* France. They are part of France and the *European Union*, though *special* EU rules apply to them.
- ^{^17} Mayotte became the 101st department of France on 31 March 2011. The *INSEE* code of Mayotte is 976 (975 is already assigned to the French overseas collectivity of *Saint Pierre and Miquelon*)
- ^{^18} *Metropoles* with territorial collectivity statute.
- ^{^19} Corsica was divided into two departments (*Golo* and *Liamone*) from 1793 to 1811, and again into two departments (*Corse-du-Sud*, number 2A, and *Haute-Corse*, number 2B) in 1975. As of 2019, *Corse-du-Sud* and *Haute-Corse* are still administrative departments, although they no longer have the status of departmental "territorial collectivities": region and department functions have been managed by a "single territorial collectivity" since 2018.

Former departments

Former departments of the current territory of France

No.	Department	Prefecture	Dates in existence	Named after	Subsequent history
–	<u>Rhône-et-Loire</u>	<u>Lyon</u>	1790–1793	<u>Rhône</u> and <u>Loire</u> rivers	Divided into <u>Rhône</u> and <u>Loire</u> .
–	<u>Corse</u>	<u>Bastia</u>		<u>Island of Corsica</u>	Divided into <u>Golo</u> and <u>Liamone</u> .
–	<u>Golo</u>		1793–1811	<u>Golo</u> (river)	Reunited with <u>Liamone</u> into <u>Corse</u> .
–	<u>Liamone</u>	<u>Ajaccio</u>		<u>Liamone</u> (river)	Reunited with <u>Golo</u> into <u>Corse</u> .
–	<u>Mont-Blanc</u>	<u>Chambéry</u>	1792–1815	<u>Mont Blanc</u> mountain	Formed from part of the Duchy of Savoy, a territory of the Kingdom of Piedmont-Sardinia which was restored to its former status at the <u>Treaty of Paris</u> (1815). The territory returned to French rule in 1860 and it corresponds approximately to the present departments of <u>Savoie</u> and <u>Haute-Savoie</u> .
–	<u>Léman</u>	<u>Geneva</u>	1798–1814	<u>Lake Geneva</u>	Formed when the Republic of Geneva was annexed into the <u>French First Republic</u> and added to territory taken from other departments. Corresponds to the present Swiss canton of Geneva and parts of the current departments of <u>Ain</u> and <u>Haute-Savoie</u> .
–	<u>Meurthe</u>	<u>Nancy</u>	1790–1871	<u>Meurthe</u> (river)	Ceased to exist following the annexation of <u>Alsace-Lorraine</u> by the German Empire in 1871 and was not recreated after the province was restored to France by the <u>Treaty of Versailles</u> .
75	<u>Seine</u>	<u>Paris</u>	1790–1967	<u>Seine</u> (river)	Divided into four new departments on 1 January 1968: <u>Paris</u> , <u>Hauts-de-Seine</u> , <u>Seine-Saint-Denis</u> , and <u>Val-de-Marne</u> (the last also incorporating a small amount of territory from <u>Seine-et-Oise</u>).
78	<u>Seine-et-Oise</u>	<u>Versailles</u>		<u>Seine</u> and <u>Oise</u> rivers	Divided into four new departments on 1 January 1968: <u>Yvelines</u> , <u>Val-d'Oise</u> , <u>Essonne</u> , <u>Val-de-Marne</u> (the last largely comprising territory from <u>Seine</u>).
20	<u>Corse</u>	<u>Ajaccio</u>	1811–1975	<u>Island of Corsica</u>	Divided into <u>Corse-du-Sud</u> and <u>Haute-Corse</u> .
975	<u>Saint Pierre and Miquelon</u>	<u>Saint-Pierre</u>	1976–1985	<u>Islands of Saint Pierre and Miquelon</u>	Converted to an <u>overseas collectivity</u> .

Departments of Algeria (*Départements d'Algérie*)

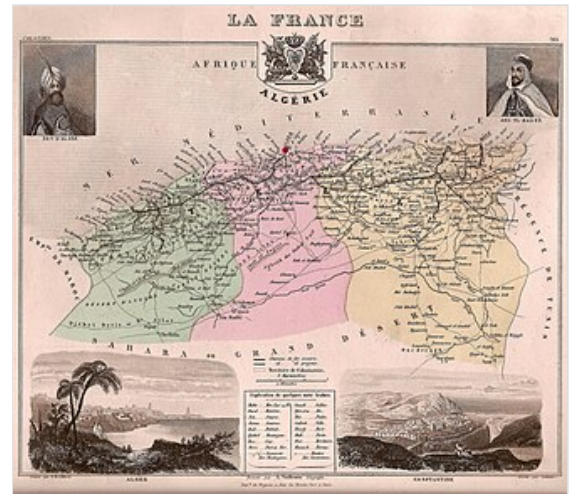
Unlike the rest of the French possessions in Africa, Algeria was divided into departments just like Corsica and Normandy from 1848 until its independence in 1962. These departments were supposed to be "assimilated" or "integrated" into France sometime in the future.

Before 1957

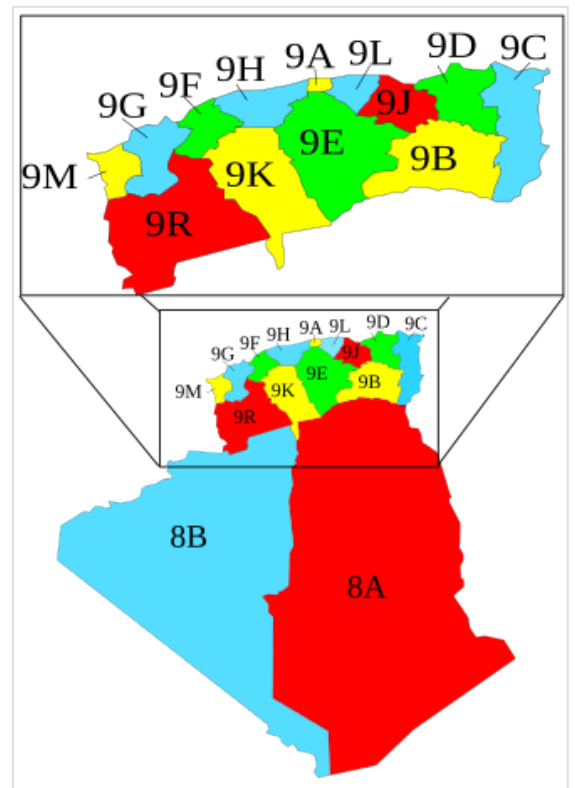
No.	Department	Prefecture	Dates of existence
91	<u>Alger</u>	<u>Algiers</u>	1848–1957
92	<u>Oran</u>	<u>Oran</u>	
93	<u>Constantine</u>	<u>Constantine</u>	
–	<u>Bône</u>	<u>Annaba</u>	1955–1957

1957–1962

No.	Department	Prefecture	Dates of existence
8A	<u>Oasis</u>	<u>Ouargla</u>	1957–1962
8B	<u>Saoura</u>	<u>Béchar</u>	
9A	<u>Alger</u>	<u>Algiers</u>	
9B	<u>Batna</u>	<u>Batna</u>	
9C	<u>Bône</u>	<u>Annaba</u>	1955–1962
9D	<u>Constantine</u>	<u>Constantine</u>	1957–1962
9E	<u>Médéa</u>	<u>Médéa</u>	
9F	<u>Mostaganem</u>	<u>Mostaganem</u>	
9G	<u>Oran</u>	<u>Oran</u>	
9H	<u>Orléansville</u>	<u>Chlef</u>	
9J	<u>Sétif</u>	<u>Sétif</u>	
9K	<u>Tiaret</u>	<u>Tiaret</u>	
9L	<u>Tizi Ouzou</u>	<u>Tizi Ouzou</u>	
9M	<u>Tlemcen</u>	<u>Tlemcen</u>	
9N	<u>Aumale</u>	<u>Sour El-Ghozlane</u>	1958–1959
9P	<u>Bougie</u>	<u>Béjaïa</u>	1958–1962
9R	<u>Saïda</u>	<u>Saïda</u>	



The three Algerian departments in 1848



Departments of French Algeria from 1957 to 1962

Departments in former French colonies

Department	Named after	Current location	Dates in existence
<u>Département du Sud</u>	<u>South</u> cardinal direction	<u>Haiti</u>	1795–1800
<u>Département d'Inganne</u>		<u>Dominican Republic</u> , <u>Haiti</u>	
<u>Département du Nord</u>	<u>North</u> cardinal direction	<u>Haiti</u>	
<u>Département de l'Ouest</u>	<u>West</u> cardinal direction		
<u>Département de Samana</u>	<u>Samaná Bay</u>	<u>Dominican Republic</u>	
<u>Sainte-Lucie</u>	Island of <u>St Lucia</u>	<u>Saint Lucia</u> , <u>Tobago</u>	
<u>Île de France</u>	Island of <u>Mauritius</u>	<u>Mauritius</u> , <u>Seychelles</u>	
<u>Indes-Orientales</u>	India and East cardinal direction	India: <u>Pondicherry Union Territory</u> (<u>Pondichéry</u> , <u>Karikal</u> , <u>Yanaon</u> , <u>Mahé</u>) <u>West Bengal</u> (<u>Chandernagore</u>)	

Departments of the Napoleonic Empire in Europe

There are a number of former departments in territories conquered by France during the French Revolution and Napoleonic Empire that are now not part of France:

Department	Prefecture (French name if different)	Named after	Current location ¹	Contemporary location ²	Dates in existence
<u>Mont-Terrible</u>	<u>Porrentruy</u>	<u>Mont Terri</u> mountain	Switzerland France (Doubs)	Holy Roman Empire: <u>Prince-Bishopric of Basel³</u> <u>County of Montbéliard</u>	1793– 1800
<u>Dyle</u>	<u>Brussels</u> <i>Bruxelles</i>	<u>Dyle</u> (river)	Belgium	Austrian Netherlands: <u>Duchy of Brabant</u> <u>County of Hainaut</u>	1795– 1814
<u>Escaut</u>	<u>Ghent</u> <i>Gand</i>	<u>Scheldt</u> river	Belgium Netherlands	Austrian Netherlands: <u>County of Flanders</u> Dutch Republic: <u>Flanders of the States</u>	
<u>Forêts</u>	<u>Luxembourg</u>	<u>Ardennes</u> forest	Luxembourg Belgium Germany	Austrian Netherlands: <u>Duchy of Luxembourg</u>	
<u>Jemmapes</u>	<u>Mons</u>	<u>Battle of Jemappes</u>	Belgium	Austrian Netherlands: <u>County of Hainaut</u> <u>Lordship of Tournai</u> <u>County of Namur</u> Holy Roman Empire: <u>Prince-Bishopric of Liège</u>	
<u>Lys</u>	<u>Bruges</u>	<u>Lys</u> (river)		Austrian Netherlands: <u>County of Flanders</u>	
<u>Meuse- Inférieure</u>	<u>Maastricht</u> <i>Maëstricht</i>	<u>Meuse</u> river	Belgium Netherlands	Austrian Netherlands: <u>Austrian Upper Guelders</u> <u>Duchy of Limburg</u> Dutch Republic: <u>Dutch Upper Guelders</u> <u>Overmaas of the States</u> Holy Roman Empire: <u>Prince-Bishopric of Liège:</u> <u>County of Horne</u> <u>County of Loon</u> <u>Thorn Abbey</u> <u>Maastricht⁵</u>	
<u>Deux-Nèthes</u>	<u>Antwerp</u> <i>Anvers</i>	Two branches of the <u>Nete</u> (river)		Austrian Netherlands: <u>Duchy of Brabant</u>	

				<u>Dutch Republic:</u> <u>Brabant of the States</u> (after 1810)	
<u>Ourthe</u>	<u>Liège</u>	<u>Ourthe</u> river	Belgium Germany	<u>Austrian Netherlands:</u> <u>Duchy of Brabant</u> <u>Duchy of Limburg</u> <u>Duchy of Luxembourg</u> <u>County of Namur</u> <u>Holy Roman Empire:</u> <u>Prince-Bishopric of Liège</u> <u>Imperial Abbey of Stavelot-Malmedy</u>	
<u>Sambre-et-Meuse</u>	<u>Namur</u>	<u>Sambre</u> and <u>Meuse</u> rivers	Belgium	<u>Austrian Netherlands:</u> <u>Duchy of Brabant</u> <u>Duchy of Luxembourg</u> <u>Holy Roman Empire:</u> <u>Prince-Bishopric of Liège</u>	
<u>Corcyre</u>	<u>Corfu</u> <i>Corfou</i>	Island of <u>Corfu</u> (archaic French form)	Greece	<u>Republic of Venice</u> ⁴	1797–1799
<u>Ithaque</u>	<u>Argostoli</u>	Island of <u>Ithaca</u>			1797–1798
<u>Mer-Égée</u>	<u>Zakynthos</u> <i>Zante</i>	<u>Aegean</u> Sea			
<u>Mont-Tonnerre</u>	<u>Mainz</u> <i>Mayence</i>	<u>Donnersberg</u> mountain	Germany	<u>Holy Roman Empire:</u> <u>Archbishopric of Mainz</u> <u>Electorate of the Palatinate</u> <u>Bishopric of Speyer</u>	1801–1814
<u>Rhin-et-Moselle</u>	<u>Koblenz</u> <i>Coblence</i>	<u>Rhine</u> and <u>Moselle</u> rivers		<u>Holy Roman Empire:</u> <u>Archbishopric of Cologne</u> <u>Electorate of the Palatinate</u> <u>Archbishopric of Trier</u>	
<u>Roer</u>	<u>Aachen</u> <i>Aix-la-Chapelle</i>	<u>Roer</u> river	Germany Netherlands	<u>Holy Roman Empire:</u> <u>Free Imperial City of Aachen</u> <u>Archbishopric of Cologne</u> <u>Electorate of the Palatinate:</u> <u>Grand Duchy of Berg</u> <u>Duchy of Jülich</u>	

				<u>Kingdom of Prussia:</u> <u>Prussian Guelders</u> <u>Imperial Free City of</u> <u>Wesel (after 1805)</u>	
<u>Sarre</u>	<u>Trier</u> <i>Trèves</i>	<u>Saar (river)</u>	Belgium Germany	<u>Holy Roman Empire:</u> <u>Electorate of the</u> <u>Palatinate:</u> <u>County of</u> <u>Veldenz</u> <u>Duchy of Zweibrücken</u> <u>Archbishopric of Trier</u>	
<u>Doire</u>	<u>Ivrea</u> <i>Ivrée</i>	<u>Dora Baltea</u> river	Italy	<u>Kingdom of Piedmont-</u> <u>Sardinia:</u> <u>Duchy of Savoy</u>	1802– 1814
<u>Marengo</u>	<u>Alessandria</u> <i>Alexandrie</i>	<u>Battle of</u> <u>Marengo</u>			
<u>Pô</u>	<u>Turin</u>	<u>Po (river)</u>			
<u>Sésia</u>	<u>Vercelli</u> <i>Vercell</i>	<u>Sesia river</u>			
<u>Stura</u>	<u>Cuneo</u> <i>Coni</i>	<u>Stura di</u> <u>Demonte river</u>			
<u>Tanaro</u> ⁶	<u>Asti</u>	<u>Tanaro (river)</u>			1802– 1805
<u>Apennins</u>	<u>Chiavari</u>	<u>Apennine</u> <u>Mountains</u>		<u>Republic of Genoa</u> ⁷	1805– 1814
<u>Gênes</u>	<u>Genoa</u> <i>Gênes</i>	<u>City of Genoa</u>			
<u>Montenotte</u>	<u>Savona</u> <i>Savone</i>	<u>Battle of</u> <u>Montenotte</u>		<u>Grand Duchy of Tuscany</u> ⁸	1808– 1814
<u>Arno</u>	<u>Florence</u>	<u>Arno (river)</u>			
<u>Méditerranée</u> (department)	<u>Livorno</u> <i>Livourne</i>	<u>Mediterranean</u> <u>Sea</u>		<u>Holy Roman Empire:</u> <u>Duchy of Parma &</u> <u>Piacenza</u>	
<u>Ombrone</u>	<u>Siena</u> <i>Sienna</i>	<u>Ombrone river</u>			
<u>Taro</u>	<u>Parma</u> <i>Parme</i>	<u>Taro (river)</u>		<u>Papal States</u>	1809– 1814
<u>Rome</u> ⁹	<u>Rome</u>	<u>City of Rome</u>			
<u>Trasimène</u>	<u>Spoletto</u> <i>Spolète</i>	<u>Lake Trasimeno</u>			
<u>Bouches-du-</u> <u>Rhin</u>	<u>'s-</u> <u>Hertogenbosch</u> <i>Bois-le-Duc</i>	<u>Rhine river</u>	Netherlands	<u>Dutch Republic:</u> ¹⁰ <u>Batavian Brabant</u> <u>(Brabant of the States)</u> <u>Dutch Guelders</u>	1810– 1814
<u>Bouches-de-</u> <u>l'Escaut</u>	<u>Middelburg</u> <i>Middelbourg</i>	<u>Scheldt river</u>		<u>Dutch Republic:</u> ¹⁰ <u>County of Zeeland</u>	

<u>Simplon</u>	<u>Sion</u>	<u>Simplon Pass</u>	Switzerland	<u>République des Sept-Dizains</u> ¹¹	
<u>Bouches-de-la-Meuse</u>	<u>The Hague</u> <i>La Haye</i>	<u>Meuse river</u>	Netherlands	<u>Dutch Republic</u> : ¹⁰ <u>County of Holland</u>	1811–1814
<u>Bouches-de-l'Yssel</u>	<u>Zwolle</u>	<u>IJssel river</u>		<u>Dutch Republic</u> : ¹⁰ <u>Overijssel</u>	
<u>Ems-Occidental</u>	<u>Groningen</u> <i>Groningue</i>	<u>Ems (river)</u>	Netherlands Germany	<u>Dutch Republic</u> : ¹⁰ <u>Dutch Upper Guelders</u>	
<u>Ems-Oriental</u>	<u>Aurich</u>		Germany	<u>Holy Roman Empire</u> : <u>Kingdom of Prussia</u> : <u>County of East Frisia</u> ¹⁰	
<u>Frise</u>	<u>Leeuwarden</u> <i>Leuwarden</i>	<u>Friesland region</u>	Netherlands	<u>Dutch Republic</u> : ¹⁰ <u>Friesland</u>	
<u>Yssel-Supérieur</u>	<u>Arnhem</u>	<u>IJssel river</u>		<u>Dutch Republic</u> : ¹⁰ <u>Dutch Upper Guelders</u>	
<u>Zuyderzée</u>	<u>Amsterdam</u>	<u>Zuiderzee inlet</u>		<u>Dutch Republic</u> : ¹⁰ <u>County of Holland</u> <u>Lordship of Utrecht</u>	
<u>Bouches-de-l'Elbe</u>	<u>Hamburg</u> <i>Hambourg</i>	<u>Elbe river</u>	Germany	<u>Holy Roman Empire</u> : <u>Free Hanseatic City of Hamburg</u> <u>Electorate of Hanover</u> <u>Free Hanseatic City of Lübeck</u>	
<u>Bouches-du-Weser</u>	<u>Bremen</u> <i>Brême</i>	<u>Weser river</u>		<u>Holy Roman Empire</u> : <u>Free Hanseatic City of Bremen</u> <u>Electorate of Hanover</u> <u>Duchy of Oldenburg</u>	
<u>Ems-Supérieur</u>	<u>Osnabrück</u>	<u>Ems (river)</u>		<u>Holy Roman Empire</u> : <u>Electorate of Hanover</u> <u>Bishopric of Osnabrück</u> <u>Kingdom of Prussia</u> : <u>Town and County of Lingen</u> <u>Principality of Minden</u> <u>County of Ravensberg</u>	

<u>Lippe</u> ¹²	Münster <i>Munster</i>	<u>Lippe (river)</u>		Holy Roman Empire: <u>Bishopric of Münster</u> <u>Electorate of the Palatinate:</u> <u>Grand Duchy of Berg</u>	
<u>Bouches-de-l'Èbre</u>	Lleida <i>Lérida</i>	<u>Ebro river</u>	Spain	Kingdom of Spain: <u>Catalonia</u>	1812–1813
<u>Montserrat</u>	Barcelona <i>Barcelone</i>	<u>Montserrat (mountain)</u>			
<u>Ter</u>	Girona <i>Gérone</i>	<u>Ter (river)</u>			
<u>Sègre</u>	Puigcerdà <i>Puigcerda</i>	<u>Segre (river)</u>	Spain Andorra	Kingdom of Spain: <u>Catalonia</u> <u>Principality of Andorra</u>	
<u>Bouches-de-l'Èbre-Montserrat</u>	Barcelona <i>Barcelone</i>	Ebro river and Montserrat mountain	<i>Previously the departments of Bouches-de-l'Èbre and Montserrat</i>		1813–1814
<u>Sègre-Ter</u>	Girona <i>Gérone</i>	Segre and Ter rivers	<i>Previously the departments of Sègre and Ter</i>		

Notes for Table 7:

- Where a Napoleonic department was composed of parts from more than one country, the nation-state containing the prefecture is listed. Please expand this table to list all countries containing significant parts of the department.
- Territories that were a part of Austrian Netherlands were also a part of Holy Roman Empire.
- The Bishopric of Basel was a German Prince-Bishopric, not to be confused with the adjacent Swiss Canton of Basel.
- The Ionian Islands were annexed by France after the Fall of the Republic of Venice. They were lost to France, becoming the Septinsular Republic, a Russo-Ottoman vassal state, from 1800 to 1807, before reverting to France at the Treaty of Tilsit. The second period of French rule lasted until 1810/14, after which these territories became a British protectorate, as the United States of the Ionian Islands
- Maastricht was a condominium of the Dutch Republic and the Prince-Bishopric of Liège.
- On 6 June 1805, as a result of the annexation of the Ligurian Republic (the puppet successor state to the Republic of Genoa), Tanaro was abolished and its territory divided between the departments of Marengo, Montenotte and Stura.
- Before becoming the department of Apennins, the Republic of Genoa was converted to a puppet successor state, the Ligurian Republic.
- Before becoming the department of Arno, the Grand Duchy of Tuscany was converted to a puppet successor state, the Kingdom of Etruria.
- Rome was known as the *department du Tibre* until 1810.
- Before becoming the departments of Bouches-du-Rhin, Bouches-de-l'Escaut, Bouches-de-la-Meuse, Bouches-de-l'Yssel, Ems-Occidental, Frise, Yssel-Supérieur and Zuyderzée, these territories of the Dutch Republic were converted to a puppet successor state, the Batavian Republic (1795–1806), then those territories that had not already been annexed (all except the first two departments here), along with the Prussian County of East Frisia, were converted to another puppet state, the Kingdom of Holland.
- Before becoming the department of Simplon, the *République des Sept Dizains* was converted to a revolutionary *République du Valais* (16 March 1798) which was swiftly incorporated (1 May 1798) into the puppet Helvetic Republic until 1802 when it became the independent Rhodanic Republic.

12. In the months before Lippe was formed, the arrondissements of Rees and Münster were part of Yssel-Supérieur, the arrondissement of Steinfurt was part of Bouches-de-l'Yssel and the arrondissement of Neuenhaus was part of Ems-Occidental.

See also

- [ISO 3166-2:FR](#)
- [List of French departments by population, area and population density](#)
- [Overseas departments and regions of France](#)

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